

SCOTTISH HIGHLANDS

Britain's last wilderness

The Highlands of Scotland are both culturally and ecologically distinct. The region encompasses ancient rocky mountains with highly complex geology, grassy plateaus, peat bogs, abundant small rivers and lochs, and remnants of native forest, as well as extensive plantations and vast swathes of heather moorland. Some authorities also classify the Hebridean islands as Highland areas, though most of these are relatively low-lying. The relative wildness of the region is due to the limited opportunities for intensive agriculture and a sparse human population.

Restoring native forest

The highest summits are well above the treeline, and include Britain's highest peak, Ben Nevis, at 4,409ft (1,344m), and the Cairngorm plateau resembles subarctic tundra in terms of plant and animal diversity. Meanwhile the lowlands bear the hallmarks of glaciation, with

broad valleys, large meandering rivers, and extensive bogs. Most of the forest in the region is coniferous plantation containing non-native Norway and sitka spruce and Douglas fir, but forest managers are increasingly looking to restore more natural assemblages similar to the ancient Caledonian forest that once cloaked lower slopes in Scots pine, juniper, birch, willow, rowan, and aspen.

Other attempts to rebalance the region's ecology include the reintroduction of Eurasian beavers, extinct for 400 years, and a high-profile rewilding experiment on the private Alladale Wilderness Reserve, where the aim is to have gray wolves and brown bears living free within a substantial fenced area.



SMALL WONDERS
Wood ants perform vital ecological roles: aerating soil, dispersing seeds, controlling problem insects, and providing food for many other species. Their nests are also home to the tiny shining guest ant, woodlice, and chafer beetle grubs.

Only 1.2% of ancient Caledonian forest remains, split across 84 sites

GROUSE MOORS
Vast areas of moorland are intensively managed to ensure an abundance of red grouse for shooting. Ruthless predator control and burning of heather to promote tender new growth for the grouse to eat are controversial practices.

RED GROUSE

BLANKET BOGS

Scotland holds a significant proportion of the world's blanket bogs, where peat is formed from dead moss, especially sphagnum. The amount of atmospheric carbon bound up in peat plays a key role in moderating climate change.

SPHAGNUM MOSS

Ben Nevis is the